

DEADLY PLOT

A swiftly coordinated crackdown by police forces and security agencies from eight states yields vital clues to the serial blasts across the country. The leads point to a single home-grown jihadi group behind all the recent terror attacks.

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THE INFORMER

A man in Bharuch who had rented out a house to four persons saw a newspaper report and recognised the two cars used in the Ahmedabad blasts as the same cars were used by them. He informed Ahmedabad Crime Branch. The quartet turned out to be SIMI terrorists.

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THE IB LEAD

The Intelligence Bureau informed the police that Zahid Sheikh, an old SIMI hand, was involved. Zahid was picked up on August 3 and he revealed the names of two more accomplices, Sajid Mansuri and Imran Sheikh, on the third day.

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PHONES

Zahid's further inputs along with Imran's and monitoring of the phones of Vadodara-based SIMI activists led police to Yunus Mansuri, Samsuddin Sheikh, Mohammed Arif Kagzi and Gyasuddin Ansari.

■ By Uday Mahurkar

As India celebrated her 61st Independence Day, police officials of the Ahmedabad crime branch were busy in their office in Gaekwad Haveli. A team led by Joint Commissioner Ashish Bhatia and Deputy Commissioner Abhay Chudasama was interrogating some of the 43 suspects detained for the July 26 Ahmedabad blasts. They were allegedly linked to the banned Students Islamic Movement of India (SIMI), now rechristened Indian Mujahideen (IM). The team was trying to unearth leads to the several unsolved blast cases that rocked the country over the past three years from Mumbai to Varanasi to Jaipur to Hyderabad. By noon, their efforts had begun to yield results.

By 8.30 p.m., a country-wide list of about 84 SIMI activists culled from the interrogation was faxed to the police of Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and Kerala. The action was swift. By the next day, 80 of the suspects in the fax list had been picked up across the seven states.

However, the only glitch came from Uttar Pradesh where senior police officials were reluctant to hand over Mufti Abu Bashir, 28, to the Gujarat Police. Bashir, a

resident of Azamgarh district, is the main accused in the Ahmedabad blasts case. A Gujarat cop—who was interrogating Bashir in Lucknow—threatened to shoot him if they didn't get an instant transit remand to take Bashir to Gujarat. The hesitation of the Uttar Pradesh Police to hand him over was apparently due to political pressure.

The picture that emerged from interrogation of the suspects—now 89 in all with 35 from Gujarat alone—was both alarming and heartening. It yielded vital clues to the 2006 Mumbai blasts, the Jaipur blasts, the Hyderabad Lumbini Park blasts and the Uttar Pradesh court blasts. Leads are also expected in the Samjhauta Express and Malegaon blasts. However, the fresh picture of the SIMI network showed that a new and deadlier organisation had emerged, capable of planning and executing devastating blasts on its own without any logistical support.

The breakthrough in the Ahmedabad blasts by the Gujarat Police and national security agencies has discredited the belief of the intelligence agencies that SIMI was not involved in direct action and that it was running for cover after its ban. Instead, it emerged that SIMI had not only grown but had also acquired striking capability with regard to planning and executing terror operations. As Bhatia, an expert on SIMI, puts it, "In all, five terror training camps

TERROR CAMPS

Their interrogation revealed the involvement of SIMI activists who attended terror camps in jungles in Kerala and near Vadodara.

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